

of Buddhism. But the repressive role that all these religions have played at times, and some would argue still do play, particularly their repression of women, is not taken into consideration.

The last chapter of the book is called Post-Hindu India. Ilaiah believes Hinduism's days are numbered, and even talks of a civil war in which Hinduism will be defeated by the combined forces of the Dalit-Bahujans. When that happens, he believes "the regeneration of India begins in multiple levels of Indian society. The society and technology that the productive masses nurtured for so long will take a new life". But Ilaiah recognises that the Shudras have not yet rejected Hinduism partly because those he calls the Brahminic forces linked Independence and democracy with that religion. So there is still one major fissure in the Dalit-Bahujan alliance he foresees. Nor of course is there unity yet within the Dalit, Shudra, or tribal communities themselves. A recent report from rural Gujarat pointed out that Dalits of the more highly regarded castes treat other Dalits as untouchable while the political geography of Bihar and Uttar

"The Indian nation is on the course for a civil war; a civil war that has been simmering as an undercurrent of the caste-based cultural system."

Pradesh is evidence that the OBCs are not united.

Because this book is a polemic, it's one-sided and so loses some of its impact. At one stage Ilaiah suggests that because Hinduism is not egalitarian and pluralist, it cannot last long. But it has, and that must surely be because it has positive attributes. Ironically, just at the time Ilaiah is prophesying the end of Hinduism, admiration of its spiritual teaching and practices is spreading in other parts of the world. Admittedly the same cannot be said for the caste system which has few defenders anywhere, and Ilaiah would argue that the caste system is the essence of Hinduism. But surely the Gita, revered by Gandhi as his Bible, and by distinguished thinkers of different faiths too, cannot be written off just because it is set in the context of a war.

Now that Ilaiah has got his polemic off his chest, might he not think of publishing a reasoned dialogue between himself and those who do not see Hinduism as wholly inimical to egalitarian democracy? The danger is that many people will write off this book as extremist. It is a danger because we need to be aware of the depth of anger and hurt it reveals. I have to say that, when I look back on what I have written, I have not been as aware of this as I should have been. ■

Love in Vizag

Still nostalgic about his country, Zama returns to his successful marriage bureau

By Geeta Doctor



THE MANY
CONDITIONS
OF LOVE

by FARAHAD ZAMA

Abacus

Price: Rs 295

Pages: 308

For those who like their fictions light and easy, there's nothing like another whirl through Zany Zama's marriage bureau in Vizag.

Vizag where you might ask? It's that distant port on the Coromandel Coast, known as Vishakhapatnam in some circles that Farahad Zama has cannily put on the map of India Lite by concocting a sweetly sentimental trip down memory lane and into a marriage bureau that might have appeared in a short story by R.K. Narayan a long time ago in Malgudi. It's pap for the patriots, the sort who live in a genteel suburb of some distant land, the UK for instance, as Zama does, dreaming of the scent of ripening mango blossoms and long afternoons where the sound of the waves pounding the beach with rhythmical intensity bring to mind ancient Arab tales of lovers seeking their beloved. In short, he is a romantic with an incurable itch for his home country that only gets better as he contemplates it from afar.

His second book is not so much a sequel as a reprise of the first book. In it we knew that Aruna, the poor but good Andhra girl who runs Mr Ali's marriage bureau was happily married to a rich boy, a doctor from a socially upwardly inclined family. That the Alis' son, Rehman had been saved from an excess of reformist zeal and the marriage bureau itself well-established under Mrs Ali's commonsensical gaze.

"Ah, not so," Zama assures us as he embarks on another round of snooping around Mr Ali's marriage bureau. Rehman's life choices have to be sorted out as he falls in love with a beautiful television news reader named Usha. There's also a back story, where he finds himself involved with the problems of rural India and the father of a girl he once loved in his college days that touches upon the issue of raising Bt Cotton and the subject of farmers' suicides in the country. Aruna's world also turns out to be rocky as Ramanujam, her husband, is both passionate and prickly about family matters. Zama sounds too much like an agony aunt for most of the time, but there are some superb vignettes that he produces as for instance the marriage solemnised between a pair of monkeys.

If not anything else, Mrs Ali scores again by giving the reader a succulent recipe for bone soup. Sip it with your Zama. ■